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Bluesky rolls out massive revamp to policies and Community Guidelines

Two years after launching, social network Bluesky is revising its [Community Guidelines](#) and [other policies](#), and asking for feedback from its users on some of the changes. The startup, a competitor to X, Threads, and open networks like Mastodon, [says its new policies](#) are meant to offer improved clarity and more detail around its user safety procedures and the appeals process.

Many of the changes are being driven by new global regulations, including the U.K.'s Online Safety Act (OSA), the EU's Digital Services Act (DSA), and the U.S.'s TAKE IT DOWN Act.

Some of the changes represent an effort by Bluesky to purposefully shape its community and the behavior of its users, nudging them to be nicer and more respectful of others. This comes after a series of complaints and media articles suggesting the community has a tendency toward self-seriousness, [bad news sharing](#), and [a lack of humor](#) and [diversity of thought](#).
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For regulatory compliance, [Bluesky's Terms of Service](#) has been updated to comply with online safety laws and regulations and to require age assurance where required. For instance, in July, the U.K.'s Online Safety Act began requiring that platforms with adult content implement age verification, which means [Bluesky users in the country](#) have to either scan their face, upload their ID, or enter a payment card to use the site.

The process for complaints and appeals is also now more detailed.

One notable update references an "informal dispute resolution process," where Bluesky agrees to talk on the phone with a user about their dispute before any formal dispute process takes place. "We think most disputes can be resolved informally," Bluesky [notes](#).

That's quite different from what's taking place at larger social networks, like [Facebook](#) and [Instagram](#), where users are being



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banned without any understanding of what they did wrong and no way to get in touch with the company to complain.



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Bluesky also says it will allow users to resolve certain claims of harm in court, instead of through arbitration. This is also somewhat unusual for tech companies that often [prefer to mediate](#) disputes outside the courts.

However, Bluesky users may be more interested in the proposed changes to the Community Guidelines, which they're invited to [offer feedback about](#). (The changes go into effect October 15, 2025, after the feedback period completes.)

These revised guidelines are organized around four principles: Safety First, Respect Others, Be Authentic, and Follow the Rules. These general principles are meant to guide Bluesky's moderation decisions around whether content should be labeled or removed, if the company can suspend or ban your account, or, in some cases, report you to law enforcement.

Bluesky's rules include many common-sense policies around not promoting violence or harm (including self-harm and animal abuse); not posting content that's illegal or that sexualizes minors (including in role-play); not allowing harmful actions like doxxing and other nonconsensual personal data-sharing; and not posting spam or malicious content, among other things.

It carves out provisions for journalism, parody, and satire. For instance, journalists engaged in "factual reporting" can post

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about criminal acts and violence, mental health, online safety, and other topics, like warnings of online viral challenges that may be harmful.

Where Bluesky may get into trouble is with the nuances of what’s considered a “threat,” “harm,” or “abuse.”

The policy states that users should “respect others” by not posting, promoting, or encouraging “hate, harassment, or bullying.” As an example, the policy bans exploitive deepfakes and content that “incites discrimination or hatred,” meaning posts that attack individuals or groups based on “race, ethnicity, religion, gender identity, sexual orientation, disability, or other protected traits.”

This is an area where Bluesky has faltered before, when, in earlier days, its moderation decisions [strained its relationship with the Black community](#), and in another case, [when its failure to moderate](#) angered the trans community.

More recently, the company has been facing backlash that it’s become [too left-leaning](#), where users were quick to criticize, [post hateful replies](#), and where the community generally [lacked humor](#).

The original idea behind Bluesky was to provide users with tools to create the community they want, including not only blocking and reporting tools, but also things like subscribable block lists or opt-in moderation services that align with your values. However, Bluesky users have still shown a preference for the app itself to handle much of the moderation, [railing against](#) its trust and safety department when it made decisions they disagreed with.

In addition, Bluesky’s [Privacy Policy](#) and [Copyright Policy](#) were also rewritten to comply with global laws around user rights, data transfer, retention and deletion, takedown procedures, transparency reporting, and more. These both go into effect on September 15, 2025, and there is no feedback period for either.

Topics: [Apps](#) [Bluesky](#) [Social](#)



Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor |

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having previously spent over three years at...

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APPS



X's declining Android app installs are hurting subscription revenue

Sarah Perez — 1:49 PM PDT · August 18, 2025

Elon Musk's X is struggling on Android devices in terms of new installs, even while App Store downloads grow, according to new data from app intelligence provider Appfigures. In July 2025, X downloads on Google Play saw a significant decline, as new installs dropped by 44% year-over-year worldwide, even as iOS downloads grew by 15%.

This steep drop in installs is pulling down X's overall average, leading to a 26% decrease in total mobile downloads year-

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over-year as of July. That's still slightly better than the month prior, when total downloads had fallen by 35%, thanks to another sharp drop in Android downloads, which were then down by nearly half (49%) year-over-year.

New X Downloads on Mobile by Month

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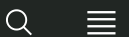
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New X Downloads on Mobile by Month with Year-Over-Year Growth

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Month	App Store	YoY	Google Play	YoY	Unified	YoY
Jan-24	2,963,000	-	6,303,000	-	9,266,000	-
Feb-24	3,623,000	-	6,352,000	-	9,975,000	-
Mar-24	3,363,000	-	6,689,000	-	10,052,000	-
Apr-24	2,971,000	-	7,536,000	-	10,507,000	-
May-24	2,993,000	-	7,676,000	-	10,669,000	-
Jun-24	3,514,000	-	8,787,000	-	12,301,000	-
Jul-24	3,429,000	-	7,742,000	-	11,171,000	-
Aug-24	3,338,000	-	7,953,000	-	11,291,000	-
Sep-24	2,679,000	-	6,347,000	-	9,026,000	-
Oct-24	2,876,000	-	5,895,000	-	8,771,000	-
Nov-24	2,629,000	-	5,735,000	-	8,364,000	-
Dec-24	2,691,000	-	5,861,000	-	8,552,000	-
Jan-25	3,312,000	12%	6,019,000	-5%	9,331,000	1%
Feb-25	3,475,000	-4%	5,535,000	-13%	9,010,000	-10%
Mar-25	3,359,000	0%	6,814,000	2%	10,173,000	1%
Apr-25	3,029,000	2%	5,032,000	-33%	8,061,000	-23%
May-25	3,370,000	13%	4,766,000	-38%	8,136,000	-24%
Jun-25	3,531,000	0%	4,451,000	-49%	7,982,000	-35%
Jul-25	3,950,000	15%	4,334,000	-44%	8,284,000	-26%

Source: Appfigures Intelligence

IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

It’s not clear where would-be X Android users are going. Rival Bluesky has seen slowing growth in recent months, and its Google Play app pulled in just 119,000 downloads in July. That’s nowhere near the millions that install X on iOS or Android every month. However, Meta’s Threads daily active users have been [catching up to X on mobile devices](#), so, possibly, some Android users could be accounted for there.

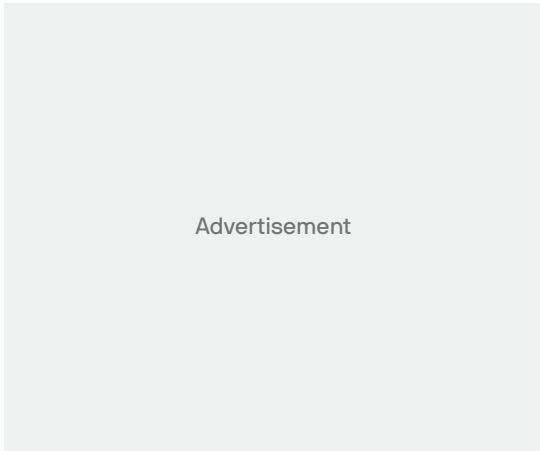
In addition to the drop in Google Play installs, X is struggling to grow its subscription revenue, Appfigures found.

In July, X earned \$16.9 million in net revenue, down from the \$18.8 million it earned in March 2025. However, that was a slight tick up from the \$16.8 million it generated in June. (Of course, X still earns the majority of its overall revenue from ads, not in-app premium subscriptions.)

While the declining demand for X on Android is partially to blame for revenue declines, X is also likely losing paying customers to Grok. The latter now has its own [stand-alone app](#) that attracts those who were buying X subscriptions primarily for the AI perks.

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Hank Green's Focus Friend app is climbing the App

Store charts — and it's extremely cute

Amanda Silberling — 10:36 AM PDT · August 18, 2025



You must stay focused. You cannot open TikTok, or Instagram, or whatever little phone games you like to play. If you fail, you will make an anthropomorphic bear very sad, because its knitting project depends on your ability to stay focused.

This is the premise of [Focus Friend](#), a productivity app created by [Honey B Games](#) and [Hank Green](#), the longtime online creator/entrepreneur/educator/[sock salesman](#). Though the app was soft launched last month, Focus Friend is only now gaining momentum on the App Store charts — likely because Green and his brother, author John Green, are [posting about it more](#) — reaching No. 4 among all free apps and No. 2 among productivity apps.

[@hankgreen1](#)

Your Deserve a Focus Friend

[🎵 original sound – Hank Green](#)

Focus Friend, which is available on [iOS](#) and [Android](#), has the bones of a typical productivity app. It invites you to set a timer on your phone, which will temporarily prevent you from opening certain apps (on iOS, the “Deep Focus Mode” setting connects to your own screen time settings, where you can designate which apps to block).

But what makes Focus Friend different is that it assigns you a new friend — a little bean — which you can give a cute name, like Garbanzo, or Susan Bean Anthony, or Eda (it's short for Edamame).

Your bean needs help focusing on its knitting. And it can only focus if you refrain from opening the apps that distract you

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from your work. If you successfully complete your focus session, your bean will give you in-game points (socks), which you can use to buy decorations for its room — because the only thing more motivating than helping a bean knit is to buy it a cute poster for its wall.

Focus Friend has a lot in common with [Finch](#), a popular self-care app that incentivizes users to maintain healthy habits by giving them a virtual bird companion. Your bird grows when you complete certain tasks that you set for yourself, like drinking water, brushing your teeth, or cleaning your room. Like the Tamagotchis of yore, these apps exploit our desire to protect a cute bundle of pixels by doing stuff that’s good for us.

Focus Friend is functional as a free app, but you can pay to give your bean different skins — you can make your bean look like a cat (a “Kitt-ney Bean”) or a jelly bean, for example. There’s also a subscription that allows your bean to knit scarves, which can be exchanged for premium decorations. Green [posted](#) on Bluesky that Focus Friend is “very much trying to be an ad-free experience because the mobile ad ecosystem kinda blows.” But the app still has to make money to compensate the employees who brought our beans to life.

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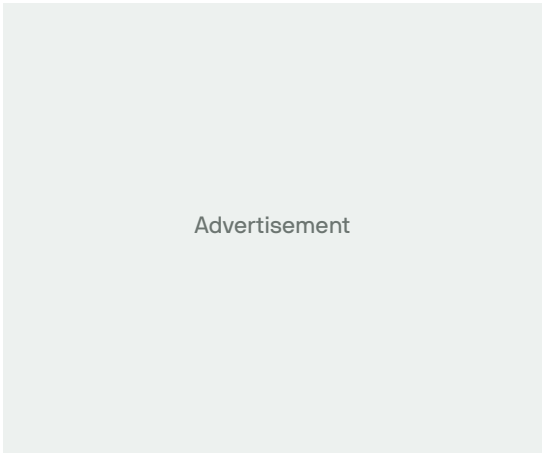
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